

TYPES OF FOSSILS

We often think of fossils as skeletons displayed in museum halls, but the evidence of prehistoric life can take many different forms. Fossils are grouped into different types depending on what part of the creature they preserve. Paleontologists have to make use of all the available fossil evidence to build as complete a view of the past as possible.



Body parts

Fossils of body parts include the actual remains of an animal, such as bones and teeth. In some rare cases, soft tissues, such as skin or feathers, are also preserved.



Footprints

The prints left behind by a moving animal on soft sediment can also be preserved as fossils. They help paleontologists understand a creature's behavior or movement.



Coprolites

Fossilized droppings, known as coprolites, reveal a lot about the animal that produced them, such as its diet, digestive system, and even the parasites that affected it.



Preserved in amber

Insects and other small animals can be trapped in sticky tree resin that then hardens over time to form amber. These fossils can preserve soft tissues, such as skin and feathers, in great detail.



3 FOSSILIZATION

Over time, minerals in water seep through the rock into the bones. The minerals turn the creature's bony remains to stone, preserving them. However, the fossil still isn't safe—the movement of rocks and other geological processes can destroy or scatter fossils before they reach the surface.

4 DISCOVERY

Millions of years later, erosion of the accumulated layers exposes the fossil. However, the exposed fossil is delicate, and paleontologists must uncover it quickly, before it is damaged or destroyed by wind and water. Fossil hunters need to arrive at the right place at the right time in order to discover and unearth the specimen.



Erosion carves away the rock, unearthing parts of the creature's skeleton.